3D printing from a file on a USB drive

What you will need

- A file of your 3D model prepared in the MakerBot format.
- A USB flash drive.

What's MakerBot format and what if I don't have that?

If you are starting with an STL file, you cannot 3D print directly. You will first need to "slice" your model in a way that is compatible with the printer. The MakerBot Sketch Print uses the proprietary `.makerbot` file format.

If this is your first time printing with the MakerBot, see the Ultimaker Cloud and Cura Slicer tutorials to find out how to go from `STL` file to `makerbot` file.

Ready, set, print!

Here are the steps at a high level:

1. Ensure the MakerBot printer is powered on using the button at the top left.
2. Insert your USB flash drive into the socket below the power button.
3. Select your file from the printer's touchpad on the right.
4. Check the preview, acknowledge the safety warnings, and watch it print.

Note: The printer will warm up and auto-level itself. This will take some time, then printing will start.

Figure 1: Top panel of the MakerBot

If any of the steps above do not work as expected, please see a member of the makerspace staff.

Watching it print

You can keep an eye on things through the front and top doors. But remember the warning about not opening them during printing. The print head is hot (200°C or nearly 400°F) and moves fast. Keep your hands out of there!

Note: Do not leave your print unattended. If things go wrong, be prepared to cancel the print job.

When it's done

The printer will let you know when it's finished with a friendly message on the front panel and a nice little tune played on its beeper. Now you can open the door.

Unsticking your part

Your 3D printed part with probably be firmly stuck to the print bed. The print surface is magnetic and by lifting the release handle, it can be removed from the print bed. You can then flex the print surface to unstick your part.

Warning: Do not overflex the print surface. It's bendy, not indestructible.

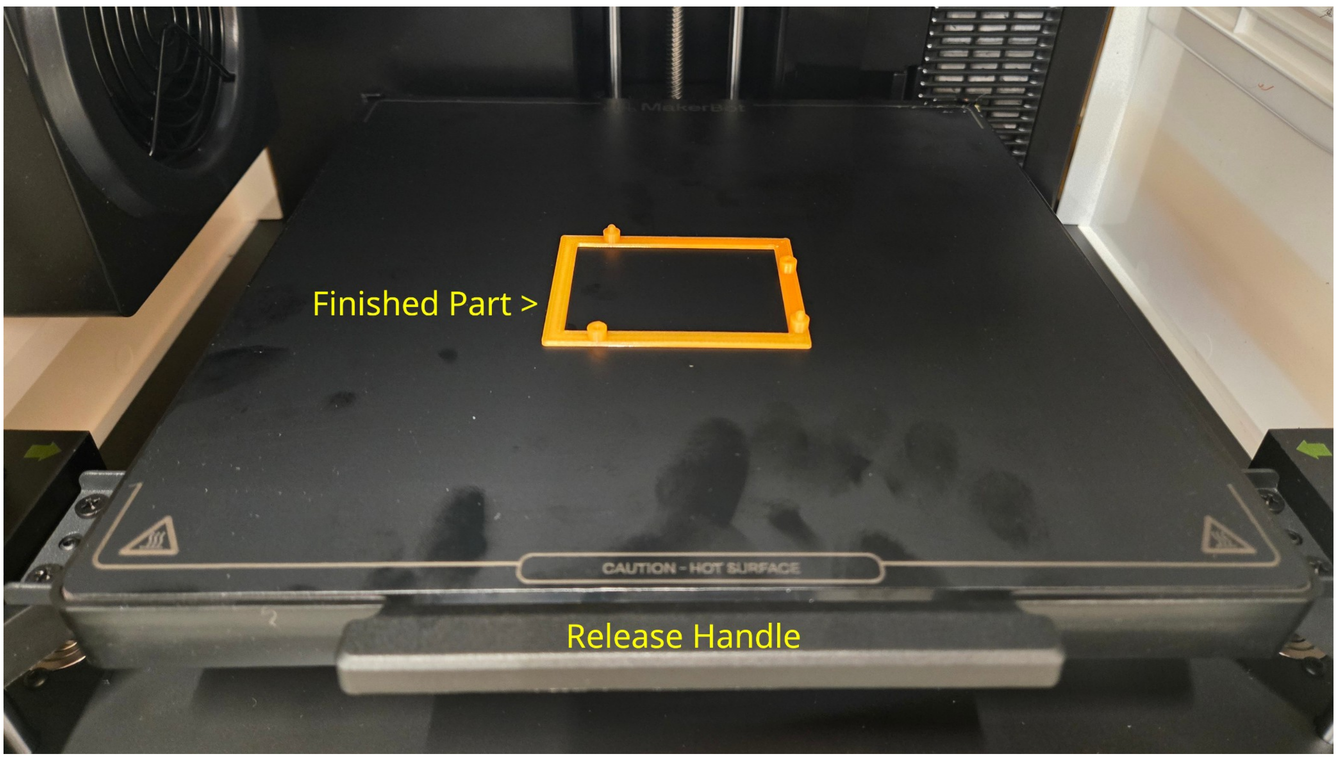

Figure 2: Interior of MakerBot showing print surface magnetically attached to print bed

Cleaning up for the next person

The printer will leave some residue on the print surface, particularly in the right, rear corner where it self-cleans. Be a good, community-minded maker and clean off any PLA residue before you leave. There is a 3D-printed scraper that can help you with this.

Ensure the removable print surface is reinstalled correctly before you leave. In particular, check the rear corners of the surface to see they are properly seated under the print bed’s tabs.

If no one else is waiting to use the printer, power it down using the front panel button.